

2

DEFINE

WHO, EXACTLY, IS AN ENTREPRENEUR?

As I travel the world talking about the Lean Startup, I'm consistently surprised that I meet people in the audience who seem out of place. In addition to the more traditional startup entrepreneurs I meet, these people are general managers, mostly working in very large companies, who are tasked with creating new ventures or product innovations. They are adept at organizational politics: they know how to form autonomous divisions with separate profit and loss statements (P&Ls) and can shield controversial teams from corporate meddling. The biggest surprise is that they are visionaries. Like the startup founders I have worked with for years, they can see the future of their industries and are prepared to take bold risks to seek out new and innovative solutions to the problems their companies face.

Mark, for example, is a manager for an extremely large company who came to one of my lectures. He is the leader of a division that recently had been chartered to bring his company into the twenty-first century by building a new suite of products designed to take advantage of the Internet. When he came to talk to me afterward, I started to give him the standard advice about how to create innovation teams inside big companies, and he stopped me in midstream: "Yeah, I've read *The Innovator's Dilemma*.¹ I've got that all taken care of." He was a long-term employee of the company and a successful manager to boot, so managing internal politics was